Commentaries on Individual Works

H 1435

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A. Background

A commentary is a work that criticizes or comments on another work. It may be published independently or in conjunction with the text of the original work. If a commentary is published with the original work, the decision to treat the item, for subject cataloging purposes, as an edition of the original work or as a commentary should parallel the treatment decision made by the descriptive cataloger in accordance with rule 6.27.1.1 of RDA, which is described below. The central feature in subject cataloging of commentaries is the assignment of a name-title or uniform title subject heading in addition to other headings. This instruction sheet describes the subject headings to be assigned to commentaries and presents criteria for deciding whether to

treat a work as an edition or as a commentary when it consists of a text or texts by one author with commentary by another. For classification of commentaries, see F 570.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from the Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Commentaries***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Groups Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***German speakers*** or ***Arabic, Students of***.

B. Recent revisions

2026-04: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Treatment of a work as an edition or as a commentary

When a text by one author is published in conjunction with commentary, exegesis, or interpretation by another author, RDA specifies that if the preferred source of information (generally the title page) presents the item as a commentary, the author of the commentary is the foundation of the authorized access point. If the item is presented as an edition, the author or uniform title of the original work is the foundation of the authorized access point. In marginal cases, main entry is made according to the judgment of the descriptive cataloger about the aspect emphasized.

This decision generally governs subject cataloging as well:

- If the authorized access point is based on the author of the commentary, the work is treated as a commentary.
- If the authorized access point is based on the author of the original work or the uniform title appropriate to the original work, the item is treated as an edition of that work.
    - If 20% or more of the work consists of commentary, the work should be assigned not only those headings, if any, appropriate to the edition of the original work but also the name-title or uniform title subject heading appropriate to commentaries, as described in section D.1, below.

D. Assignment of subject headings to commentaries

When a work is treated as a commentary, assign the following subject headings:

D.1. Name-title or uniform title subject heading

D.1.a. General rule

For works entered under an author (personal or corporate), this heading consists of the name of the author followed by a period and the title of the work with any initial article in the nominative case omitted. For works entered under the title, it consists of the uniform title alone. For sacred works and anonymous classics, see section D.1.c.

Examples:

[These examples are intended to illustrate only this heading; other headings may also be required.]

Title: Shakespeare's English comedy : The merry wives of Windsor in context.

600 10 $a Shakespeare, William, $d 1564-1616. $t Merry wives of Windsor.

Title: The church of the poor : a commentary on Paul VI's encyclical On the development of peoples.

610 20 $a Catholic Church. $b Pope (1963-1978 : Paul VI). $t Populorum progressio.

Title: Without fear or favor : the New York times and its times.

630 00 $a New York times.

With the exception of sacred works, as described in section D.1.c, such elements as language of the text, translator, version, edition, publication date, etc., are not added to this heading. For a commentary on a part of a work, such headings may include part or section designations, for example, ***Hippocrates. Epidemics. Book 6.***

D.1.b. Determining the correct form

LC practice: Generally, catalogers do not create name authority records for name-title combinations or for title-only access points. However, under certain conditions, they may be required to create such records. To ensure that the required heading is formulated correctly, proceed as follows:

1. ***Name authority record exists.*** Search in the name authority file to determine whether an RDA authority record has been created for the name-title combination or for the uniform title needed. If an RDA authority record exists, assign the heading in the form given in the record, punctuating it as described above. If an authority record has been created for an authorized access point constructed in the form ***[author]. [form conventional collective title]. Selections*** and a see reference has been made from the

form ***[author]. [title page title]***, omit the term ***Selections*** when assigning the uniform title as a subject heading.

2. ***Name authority record does not exist.*** If an authority record is not found, request a cataloger with the appropriate skills provide the proper form.
3. ***Name authority record exists but is not RDA.*** Follow standard name authority cataloging practices to update the record.

Note: Once a name-title or uniform title has been formulated by a descriptive cataloger for use as a subject heading in an RDA record, it is not necessary to request the form from the descriptive cataloger each time the heading must be assigned. Therefore, if an RDA bibliographic record exists that uses as a subject heading a name-title combination or a uniform title, assign it in the same form to any new work being cataloged. When in doubt, request the proper form from a descriptive cataloger.

D.1.c. Sacred works (including individual parts) and anonymous classics

Use as the uniform title subject heading the form of the title that would be used as the main entry for an edition of the work itself. In addition, assign the appropriate form subdivision.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Commentaries*.** Instead, assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Commentaries***, etc.

Examples:

```
Title: The Koran : an exegetical commentary.
   630 00 $a Qur'an $v Commentaries.
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LC practice:

```
   630 00 $a Qur'an.
   655 #7 $a Commentaries. $2 lcgft
```

```
Title: The concept of character in the Apocalypse.
   630 00 $a Bible. $p Revelation $x Criticism, interpretation, etc.
```

For works discussing versions of sacred works, or of their individual parts, in specific languages, assign the formulation of the uniform title that includes the language. Use the appropriate subdivision after this heading.

Example:

```
Title: A history of the English Bible.
   630 00 $a Bible. $l English $x Versions $x History.
```

D.1.d. Commentaries on commentaries

For a work that is a commentary on another commentary (a phenomenon that occurs most frequently in connection with religious texts), assign the appropriate name-title or uniform title subject heading both for the original work and for the commentary being commented upon.

D.2. Companion headings

D.2.a. General rule

In addition to the name-title or uniform title for the work being discussed, assign, if appropriate, the same topical headings that were or would be assigned to an edition of the work itself.

Note: Omit any form subdivisions, such as ***--Early works to 1800***, that were added to the headings assigned to the original work, if they are not applicable to the commentary.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Early works to 1800*.**

Examples:

Original work: Bentham, Jeremy, 1748-1832. The constitutional code.

650 #0 $a Constitutional law.

Commentary: Rosen, F. Jeremy Bentham and representative democracy : a study of the Constitutional code.

600 10 $a Bentham, Jeremy, $d 1748-1832. $t Constitutional code.

650 #0 $a Constitutional law.

655 #7 $a Commentaries. $2 lcgft

Original work: Berkeley, George, 1685-1753. A treatise concerning the principles of human knowledge.

650 #0 $a Knowledge, Theory of $v Early works to 1800.

650 #0 $a Idealism $v Early works to 1800.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Knowledge, Theory of.

650 #0 $a Idealism.

655 #7 $a Early works. $2 lcgft

Commentary: Luce, A. A. (Arthur Aston), 1882-1977. Berkeley's immaterialism : a commentary on his A treatise concerning the principles of human knowledge.

600 10 $a Berkeley, George, $d 1685-1753. $t Treatise concerning the principles of human knowledge.

650 #0 $a Knowledge, Theory of.

650 #0 $a Idealism.

655 #7 $a Commentaries. $2 lcgft

D.2.b. Textual criticism

Do not assign such headings if the commentary does not discuss the substantive matter of the original work, but is only a textual criticism. Instead, assign additional headings if needed to bring out the nature or focus of the commentary.

Example:

Original work: Aristotle. The Nicomachean ethics.

Authorized access point: Aristotle. Nicomachean ethics. English

650 #0 $a Ethics $v Early works to 1800.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Ethics.

655 #7 $a Early works. $2 lcgft

Commentary: Bywater, Ingram, 1840-1914. Contributions to the textual criticism of Aristotle's Nicomachean ethics.

600 00 $a Aristotle. $t Nicomachean ethics.

655 #7 $a Commentaries. $2 lcgft

D.2.c. Conversion of form headings to topical headings

If the headings assigned to the original work are used only as form headings, convert them to their most appropriate topical equivalents when assigning them as headings to a commentary on the work.

Examples:

Form heading	Topical equivalent
651 #0 $a Egypt $x History $v Fiction.	651 #0 $a Egypt $x In literature.
600 00 $a Yvain $v Legends.	600 00 $a Yvain $x Legends $x History and criticism.
651 #0 $a United States $x History $y Civil War, 1861-1865 $v Fiction.	651 #0 $a United States $x History $y Civil War, 1861-1865 $x Literature and the war.
650 #0 $a Agriculture $v Periodicals.	650 #0 $a Agriculture $x Periodicals $x History.

LC practice:

Topical heading with LCGFT	Topical equivalent

651 #0 $a Egypt $x History. 655 #7 $a Political fiction. $2 lcgft	651 #0 $a Egypt $x In literature.
600 00 $a Yvain. 655 #7 $a Legends. $2 lcgft	600 00 $a Yvain $x Legends $x History and criticism.
651 #0 $a United States $x History $y Civil War, 1861-1865. 655 #7 $a Historical fiction. $2 lcgft	651 #0 $a United States $x History $y Civil War, 1861-1865 $x Literature and the war.
650 #0 $a Agriculture. 655 #7 $a Periodicals. $2 lcgft	650 #0 $a Agriculture $x Periodicals $x History.

D.3. Treatment of works consisting of both original text and commentary

D.3.a. If entered under author of original work

Assign headings, if any, appropriate to the text of the original work. If the commentary is 20% or more of the work being cataloged, assign also the name-title or uniform title heading appropriate to a commentary on the work.

D.3.b. If entered under the author of the commentary

Assign the name-title or uniform title heading appropriate to a commentary on the work, and any other headings appropriate to the text of the original work.

Revision history

2026-04: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.